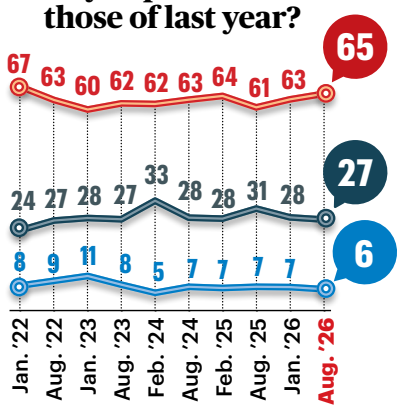
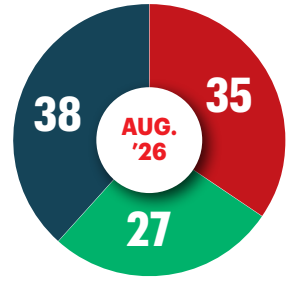
Q. How do you compare your current daily expenses with those of last year?



Current expenses have become difficult to manage
Expenses have gone up but still manageable
Current expenses have gone down; Rest: DK/ CS

Majority find daily expenses harder to manage, more so than in the previous poll

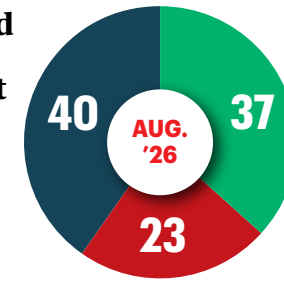
Q. Is bureaucracy a hindrance to, or facilitator of, India's economic development?



Hindrance
Facilitator
DK/ CS

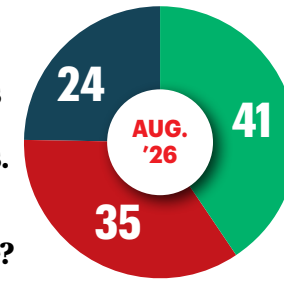
Bureaucracy is seen more as a hindrance than a facilitator, yet most respondents are unsure

Q. Should the govt disinvest in loss-making PSUs?



Yes
No
DK/ CS

Q. Govt has no business being in business. Do you agree or disagree?



Agree
Disagree
DK/ CS

Public prefers less government in business, supporting dis-investment and private enterprise

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say

the rich, up from 39.6 per cent in the January 2026 survey, while another 7.5 per cent say it has not benefited the common man at all. Also, 18.1 per cent say only the middle class has benefited from government policies, possibly a reference to the tax sops that the Centre gave to boost middle-class consumption in the February 2025 Union budget.

A follow-up question reinforces this perception. Asked who benefited most from the NDA government's economic policies, 55.7 per cent point to big businesses. Farmers, the salaried class and small businesses are seen as the biggest beneficiaries by just 8 per cent, 7.4 per cent and 6.4 per cent, respectively. The impression of an unevenly distributed recovery is hard to miss.

Yet, when compared with Manmohan Singh, prime minister of the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance government (UPA) from 2005-2014, a plurality of respondents (47.3 per cent) believe PM Narendra Modi has handled the economy better. That, however, is down from 53.5 per cent in the January poll.

FEELING THE SQUEEZE

The public's own assessment of their economic well-being reveals another fault line. A clear majority (61.6 per cent) say their economic status has either 'remained the same' or 'deteriorated' since the NDA government came to power in 2014. Only 34.2 per cent feel better off, marginally lower than the 35 per cent who said so in the January poll.

44 PER CENT of respondents feel that only the rich have benefited from India's economic growth

The outlook on the future is no more encouraging. As many as 64.2 per cent expect their household income or salary to either 'remain the same' or 'worsen', up from 62.4 per cent in January. Just 23.7 per cent expect an improvement—a sharp drop from the 28.3 per cent who felt so seven months ago.

Inflation is inching up again, driven by higher crude oil prices amid the war in West Asia and the vagaries of the monsoon that have affected agriculture. Retail inflation rose marginally to 4.5 per cent in July from 4.4 per cent in June, while inflation in food and beverages also edged up to 5.2 per cent. The Reserve Bank of India estimates retail inflation to be 5 per cent for FY27.

The pressure is already telling on household budgets. As many as 65 per cent of those polled say their 'current expenses have become difficult to manage', up from 63.2 per cent in January 2026 and 60.6 per cent in August 2025.